Checklist: 10 Steps to an Ideal Prompt

The Essential Checklist

Print this one-page checklist and keep it at your desk. One pass prevents poor AI output.

✓	Step	What to Check
1	**Role**	Who should the model be? (analyst, expert, editor)
2	**Context**	What's the situation, goal, and constraints?
3	**Audience**	Who needs to understand this? Language, level, concerns
4	**Tone**	Formal, casual, academic, marketing? One word specifies.
5	**Format**	List, essay, table, JSON, email? Spell it out.
6	**Volume**	How long? "200 words", "3 bullet points", "one paragraph"
7	**Constraints**	What must NOT appear? Forbidden phrases, jargon, links
8	**Data**	Give only what matters. Don't dump your entire base.
9	**Clarifications**	Ask: "Should I elaborate?" → Add "if..." branches
10	**Fact-check**	Request: "Verify 3 facts" — model will cite sources

Quick Fix: 3 Questions When Output is Weak

1. "What specific information is missing?"
2. "Re-write with explicit constraints."
3. "What would a senior expert add?"

Before/After Example

Before: "Write a post about productivity"

After: "**Role:** LinkedIn Content Manager **Audience:** HR managers **Tone:** Professional, actionable **Format:** LinkedIn post, 300 words max **Constraints:** No buzzwords, concrete steps only **Context:** Discuss AI tools for productivity improvement in 2026"

How to Use

1. Print this sheet
2. Run through every prompt
3. Save 30+ minutes per week on iteration fixes
4. Share this checklist with your team